TSA Mock

Critical Thinking

The hardest past TSA Critical Thinking question of every type, from all 16 papers (2008–2023)

Questions	Total marks	Time limit
25	25	45 minutes

Instructions

- You have **45 minutes** to answer all **25 questions**.
- Each question is worth **one mark**. There are no penalties for incorrect answers, so attempt every question.
- Each question has five options, A to E. Choose the one option you consider correct.
- Calculators are **not** permitted. You may use this paper for rough working.
- Every question is a real past TSA question. The year and number in brackets show where it comes from, e.g. **7 (2019 Q32)**.

What is in this paper

At least one question of each of the 10 Critical Thinking question types that have come up in past papers, chosen as the hardest of its type: Applying a principle, Assumption, Draw a conclusion, Fill the gap, Flaw, Identifying a principle, Main conclusion, Parallel reasoning, Strengthen, Weaken.

How the time limit was set

The time limit follows the TARA Critical Thinking module (22 questions in 40 minutes), scaled to 25 questions: 25 × 40 ÷ 22 = 45.45 minutes, rounded to the nearest minute (45 minutes). These are hard questions, so expect to run short of time.

Score: _____ / 25

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1 (2016 Q45) Many people criticise what they call ‘the younger generation’ for what their seniors regard as immoral behaviour. These critics need to realise that because the world has changed, moral standards have changed with it. In fact, technology is advancing so rapidly that it is only the young who understand the world in which they live. It is they, not their parents or grandparents, who should be setting moral standards. Anyone over the age of 25 cannot help but be blinded by what they learned in the past. Their education has prevented them from perceiving and responding to the demands of the modern day, and so their moral judgments have no validity.

Which one of the following best expresses the main conclusion of the above argument?

A Moral judgments made by people over the age of 25 are not valid.

B Moral standards have changed.

C Moral standards should be set by people under the age of 25.

D The younger generation is guilty of what older people regard as immoral behaviour.

E Young people are the only ones who understand the contemporary world.

2 (2015 Q41) The main reason private schools thrive in Britain is that they are extremely good at getting their students into elite universities. In the UK only 7% of students attend private schools but they account for 40% of students at Oxford and Cambridge. As entry to the top universities is dependent on examination results (particularly A-level results), private school students must be achieving higher grades than those in the state sector. Higher grades are the result of good teaching, so the teaching in private schools must be better than the teaching in state schools.

Which one of the following, if true, would most weaken the above argument?

A A-levels are not the only exams that can be used for admission to Oxford or Cambridge.

B Only people from wealthy families can go to private schools.

C More than 40% of students at Oxford and Cambridge attended state schools.

D A higher proportion of private school candidates take A-levels than those from the state sector.

E Many private schools now accept scholarship students from poorer backgrounds.

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3 (2011 Q39)

Many people who live near to mobile phone masts are worried that radiation from these masts will damage their health. Mobile phones themselves have also been suspected of emitting dangerous levels of radiation, and a report recommended that children should be discouraged from making non-essential calls. Emission of radiation from the masts is much lower than that from a mobile phone. A few seconds making a phone call is comparable to 24 hours of exposure from a mast. Radiation from both these sources is below the international guidelines as to what is a dangerous level, but no one can yet be certain if these guidelines accurately reflect the level of risk.

Which one of the following can be drawn as a conclusion from the above passage?

A People who use mobile phones are putting their health at risk.

B The international guidelines underestimate the risk to health from low levels of radiation.

C The health risk from living near a phone mast is lower than that from using a mobile phone.

D People who live near mobile phone masts overestimate the risks to their health from these masts.

E If extensive use of mobile phones is not harmful to health, radiation from a mast is unlikely to be a risk.

4 (2022 Q49)

The government has recently announced that the method by which the British Broadcasting Corporation (BBC) is funded will be changed, leading to speculation that public funding for the organisation could soon be withdrawn. One of the complaints is that BBC TV and radio presenters “make their profile at public expense”, but then earn income on top of their salaries by charging to speak at events to which they are invited purely due to their association with the BBC. However, figures show that, over the last five years, Members of Parliament (MPs) received £8.4m on top of their salaries through similar activities. Until MPs can behave in a way that is consistent with their criticisms of others, this policy to change the funding of the BBC should be scrapped.

Which one of the following, if true, most weakens the above argument?

A BBC presenters make up a small proportion of all people invited to speak at events.

B Many MPs were established public figures before they entered Parliament.

C Many MPs have second or third jobs outside Parliament.

D Invitations to BBC presenters to speak at public events do not continue once the presenter has left the BBC.

E The BBC issues clear guidelines to its employees about the types of events that they are allowed to speak at.

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5 (2011 Q29)

A recent study by a drugs company found that the amount of money spent on a specific pill used for the treatment of Alzheimer's disease in the UK showed wide regional variation. Alzheimer's is a condition associated with the ageing process. In some areas the expenditure was as low as £1 per head of the population over 65 whereas in others it was as high as £10 per head. These pills are the most effective treatment for this condition that is currently available. Therefore, this is another example of 'post-code lottery' where the effectiveness of treatment for a health condition will depend upon where you live.

Which one of the following is an assumption underlying the above argument?

A The pills are very successful in halting the progress of Alzheimer's disease.

B The drugs company that did the research doesn't have a vested interest in selling the pills.

C There are no regional variations in the incidence of Alzheimer's in the 65+ age group.

D There are no regional variations in the number of people in the 65+ age group.

E It is not possible to develop Alzheimer's disease below the age of 65.

6 (2011 Q17)

When you install a burglar alarm in your home, you do so presumably because the cost of the alarm is less than the expected benefits. The cost of a burglary, if one occurs, is likely to be much higher than the cost of fitting an alarm. A clearly visible box on an outside wall of an alarmed house alerts and discourages potential thieves. Because your house is less likely to be burgled, your neighbour's house may be more vulnerable. Therefore, while there may be little impact on overall crime levels, expensive security devices reduce crimes against those with the devices but increase crimes against those without.

Which one of the following, if true, would most weaken the above argument?

A For similar houses, a higher percentage of those without intruder alarms are burgled than those with alarms.

B As the percentage of houses with intruder alarms increased from 40% to 90%, house burglary rates fell by 60% and there was a rise in street muggings of 100%.

C Burglars perceive an alarm as a signal that there are items well worth stealing in a house, while no alarm indicates less valuable contents.

D Only 60% of houses with alarms set the alarm every day.

E Burglars know that 25% of all visible alarm boxes are fakes, but cannot tell the fake from the genuine.

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7 (2011 Q46)

Land reform is urgently needed in the UK. It is well documented that around two-thirds of Britain is owned by just 0.3% of the population. Many of the largest estates have been in the hands of the same families for centuries, and were acquired under outdated feudal laws, often by means of aggression. If these families had any sense of social justice in the 21st century they would by now have voluntarily surrendered all but the acreage they needed for personal privacy. _____ the state should confiscate all excessive land holdings without compensation and redistribute them into the families of workers and taxpayers at affordable prices.

Which of the following phrases, inserted in the blank space, most logically completes the above argument?

A In the current economic climate, ...

B On the other hand, ...

C This being the case, ...

D Therefore, on legal grounds, ...

E Since they have not, ...

8 (2011 Q33)

In a high speed police chase, police drivers sometimes lose sight of the car they are chasing. But that's no reason to give up. All they have to do is take the first left, and then the first left again. Pursued drivers are likely to keep taking turns as they come up, as this seems instinctively like the best way to lose someone who is following them. They are not going to turn right as this involves waiting and checking for oncoming traffic. Therefore take a couple of left turns and the police car will soon have their criminal in sight once again!

Which of the following, if true, would strengthen this argument?

A Car chases tend to end with the pursued driver losing control of their vehicle.

B Drivers in TV car chases tend to turn left rather than right when pursued.

C Police drivers are usually able to sustain faster average speeds over a length of time than other drivers.

D Police drivers usually request overhead assistance from a helicopter when chasing criminals in cars.

E Two left turns might take the criminal where they want to be going.

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9 (2014 Q23) The Universities Minister faced a torrent of criticism when he suggested that students could find themselves "cut-price degrees" at the last minute as universities charging the new maximum fee of £9,000 would slash prices to fill any vacant places. The chair of a group of student unions attacked the proposal, saying: "If a student qualifies for a place they will pay one amount, while someone who fails but then gets an unfilled place at the end will somehow pay less." Clearly this turns justice on its head.

Which one of the following best matches the principle underlying the above argument?

A If you wait until the last minute to book a holiday you can often pay less than if you booked well in advance.

B Someone who applies for a job after the closing date should not be appointed over someone who applied in time.

C It would be wrong in any competitive event to reward those who are second-best more than those who win outright.

D Education should not be treated like a commodity which can be bought and sold.

E A convicted criminal should not be released early just because the prisons are overcrowded.

10 (2017 Q47) In a situation where every course of action is immoral, there still remains the ability to act for the greatest good for the greatest number. Therefore, the outsiders ought to be eliminated at the least possible cost and with the least possible delay. I am sorry to arrive at that conclusion, but it is the right step.

Which one of the following best illustrates the principle contained in the above argument?

A The swiftest and cheapest option is often the least immoral action.

B The action that harms the least number of people is the best possible action.

C Where all options are immoral, it is necessary to consider cost and speed.

D An action cannot be considered totally immoral if it is the right action.

E An action cannot be considered totally immoral if it is done for the greater good.

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11 (2013 Q34) There is widespread dissatisfaction and disillusionment in Britain with politics and with politicians, who are seen as untrustworthy. Many of the electorate do not even bother to vote in a general election. In Switzerland democracy is more direct than in Britain, in the sense that many referendums take place, and many important political decisions are thus based directly on the votes of citizens rather than on those of their elected representatives. Surveys show that in those parts of Switzerland where more of these important decisions are made by referendum, the citizens are happier than in those areas where there is less opportunity to influence decisions. So if we were to adopt the Swiss system in Britain, the dissatisfied and disillusioned British electorate would be much happier.

Which one of the following identifies the flaw in the above argument?

A It assumes that most Swiss citizens vote in general elections.

B It assumes that there is only one reason why some Swiss citizens are happier.

C It assumes that British citizens would trust politicians if there were more referendums.

D It assumes that there is only one reason why the British are disillusioned with politics.

E It assumes that better policies emerge when important decisions are made by referendum.

12 (2017 Q11) Health clubs are booming. It is claimed that this must be a positive sign about modern society, in that people now appreciate that a healthy body is needed in order to sustain a healthy mind. But that claim is mistaken because what those optimistic conclusions fail to appreciate is people's ability to deceive themselves. Surely if someone is really keen to stay fit they go jogging rather than join a health club? The health club phenomenon is just an example of how easily people can be swayed by marketing. They pay to jog on the spot when they could jog around the park for free. The vast majority of members barely use their health clubs and feel they are achieving something just by paying the fees.

Which one of the following best expresses the main conclusion of the above argument?

A Health clubs deceive people into joining them.

B Most people who join health clubs are not getting healthy.

C People do not really appreciate that they must keep their bodies healthy.

D The success of health clubs is not a reliable sign of an improvement in people's health.

E We should judge the nation's health by looking at the sales of jogging shoes not health club membership.

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13 (2019 Q23) It's common for people to agree in principle to socially useful projects such as the opening of centres for people with serious mental health problems. However, if the project is planned for the area where they live, they tend to object and suggest that alternative locations would be preferable. While they approve of the general idea of such projects, they won't tolerate any negative effects on their own lives. We really don't want to go back to outdated practices of housing people with mental health problems in remote areas with no contact with the general population. So we have to accept that these projects can only work if we live near, and interact with, the people they are designed to help. Practise what you preach!

Which one of the following illustrates the principle used in the above argument?

A People who think sport has been tainted by bribery and performance-enhancing drugs should not buy tickets to sporting events.

B People who think more money should be spent on the health service should not complain when their income tax is increased to fund it.

C Parents who think too much 'screen time' is bad for young children should not buy them so many electronic gadgets.

D People who choose to be vegetarians should seek to persuade others not to eat meat or fish.

E People who have benefitted from grants or bursaries for university education should lobby for others to have the same advantages.

14 (2023 Q49) To win business investment, you need a good product and a well-developed business plan. Your product is brilliant, but you haven't spent enough time on the plan. So it's unlikely you'll get funding.

Which one of the following most closely parallels the reasoning used in the above argument?

A For the school to approve their proposal for meat-free lunches, the students must develop a menu and win support from their peers. The student body has approved their new menu in a poll, so it's unlikely the school will continue to serve meat.

B The only way their team will be disqualified is if they miss a match and fail to notify the tournament director at least three hours before the start of play. They couldn't attend the first match but told the director in plenty of time, meaning they won't be disqualified.

C The new hotel manager must be fluent in Mandarin and Korean. This candidate speaks both, meaning the hotel won't need to interview anyone else.

D To earn a distinction in music, you must perform in public concerts or write your own music composition. You don't have time for the concerts or the composition, so it's unlikely you'll earn a distinction.

E If they want to take a holiday that is affordable and unique, the friends can volunteer on a farm or at a nature reserve. The farm only hosts volunteers for the weekend, so they probably won't go there.

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15 (2023 Q21) In recent years, the production and visibility of colourised and ‘restored’ historical photographs has grown exponentially, owing to both social media and the introduction of user-friendly colourisation software. But the expansion of the technical capacity and popular appetite to alter historical photography has not been matched by sufficient debate about the assumptions and consequences of this practice. Colourisers do not address photographs as physical artefacts with unique histories of creation and reception: they treat original photos as ‘windows’ onto the past that can be ‘improved’ for viewers. But a photograph is never just a neutral representation of the past. Every photograph carries with it a complicated history of who took it, who looked at it, how it was shaped by the technology behind it, and what all this means for questions of representation, experience, and history. Colourisation blocks out this rich repository of historical meaning, substituting a fleeting jolt of novelty for deeper understanding of the image.

Which one of the following, if true, most strengthens the above argument?

A Artificial intelligence is now being used to colourise photographs automatically.

B Colourisation techniques are almost as old as photography itself.

C Some photographers of the past chose to use black and white film instead of colour.

D Some universities no longer teach courses on the history of photography.

E Colourisers rarely have academic experience of studying history.

16 (2014 Q34) A recent peaceful demonstration against government cuts ended in violence caused by relatively small numbers of 'anarchists' attacking police and property. Anarchism is a political philosophy, and as a group, anarchists tend to be unable to agree among themselves on exactly what it means. But what does it tell us about these events or about those involved if we call everyone with a brick in their hand an anarchist? Given that the central idea all anarchists have in common is the abolition of the state (not necessarily by violence), 'anarchist' is a daft way to characterise the violent hangers-on of a demonstration protesting not for but against the shrinking of the state.

Which one of the following is the best statement of the flaw in the argument above?

A The fact that some anarchists are peaceful does not mean that violent demonstrators cannot be anarchists.

B The protesters against government cuts are not protesting against a shrinking of the state.

C The presence of anarchists at a demonstration does not mean that they agree with its official aims.

D The diverse nature of anarchism makes it possible to call anyone an anarchist, as even they do not know exactly what the word means.

E The violent demonstrators want the Government to increase, not cut, spending.

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17 (2011 Q11)

The differences between human beings are sometimes more striking than the similarities. There is a minority of people who, driven by a competitive urge to be the first or the best, undertake ambitious expeditions involving severe physical deprivations, high risk of fatality, and extreme isolation. Compare these people to the majority who prefer an easy, risk free life of comfort and we can see that one human being can be as different from another in their behaviour as two different species of animal. Any attempt to form general rules about human behaviour needs to bear this variation in mind.

Which one of the following best expresses the conclusion of the passage above?

A Members of the human race can be as different in their behaviour as two separate species of animal.

B Humans who take risks in the interests of achieving unusual feats are untypical.

C Variation in human behaviour makes it difficult to generalise.

D Differences between people can be more striking than similarities.

E Human beings are superior to all other animals.

18 (2015 Q29)

Thankfully, logicians did not devise the British Constitution. It has evolved through the work of ordinary people, who have adapted the Government of the country to meet the needs of their age. They have always preserved sufficient flexibility to permit such adaptation. And we have avoided a lot of problems because we have never been guided in anything we have done by logic. If you study the period of history from the Civil War, in the middle of the 17th century, to the accession of George I in 1714, you will see the benefits of not making the Constitution too rigid by writing it down. It proves how much there is to be said for ignoring logic and following common sense.

Which one of the following is an underlying assumption of the above argument?

A As the British Constitution was devised by logicians, it cannot be adapted to meet contemporary needs.

B The need to write down the British Constitution became inevitable over time.

C Britain was fortunate that its Constitution evolved flexibly as a result of the work of ordinary people.

D It is not possible to follow both logic and common sense because they will always produce different results.

E It is always right to ignore logic and follow common sense because such a course of action produces the best results.

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19 (2022 Q45) If he was telling the truth about the incident, then we would not expect him to look so nervous talking to the police. The fact that he looks so nervous suggests he is probably lying.

Which one of the following most closely parallels the reasoning used in the above argument?

A If everyone who found themselves in the same position as Zach behaved the same way that he did, then we would be in an absolutely terrible situation. Fortunately for us, not everyone does behave in that way.

B The volume of waste they generate shows that most coffee companies do not care about the environmental impact of their businesses. If they did, they wouldn't serve coffee in disposable cups.

C If Bella really wanted to come to the party, then she would have told Anne. Unfortunately, since we are unable to contact Anne, we can't know if Bella really wanted to come.

D If Einstein's theory of relativity is correct, then we would expect light rays from distant stars to bend as they pass our own star. The fact that we are able to observe this suggests Einstein's theory is correct.

E No one who saw the game on Saturday would have thought it was between two sides at the very bottom of the league. If you'd seen the game, you would have agreed that the standard of football was impressively high.

20 (2022 Q47) One vision dominating much of urban planning worldwide is that of the 'smart city', whereby urban areas are pre-planned and designed to be managed via digital technology with efficiency prioritised as the top objective. But planners cannot foresee how cities will need to develop depending on cultural trends, changes in economic sectors, and other factors. We lose something important if we over-plan and over-manage our cities. The concept of the city as a pre-engineered machine works against critically important quality-of-life considerations. Once basic services, like transport, are in place, urban dwellers value community cohesion, opportunities for self-expression, and other quality-of-life features as much as or even more than efficiency. Such elements require openness, freedom of choice, and the opposite of central control in order to blossom.

Which one of the following best expresses the main conclusion of the above argument?

A Planners cannot foresee how cities will need to develop in response to various factors.

B We lose something important if we over-plan and over-manage our cities.

C The concept of the city as a pre-engineered machine works against important quality-of-life considerations.

D Urban dwellers value community cohesion and other quality-of-life features as much as or even more than efficiency.

E Community cohesion and other quality-of-life features require openness, freedom of choice, and the opposite of central control in order to blossom.

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21 (2014 Q47) Although boxing is unacceptable, other risky sports are not. When people get injured or killed in horse sports, motor sports or while climbing, yachting or skydiving it is because things have gone horribly wrong. When people get killed in boxing it is because things have gone horribly right. The aim of any boxing match is to cause more permanent brain damage to your opponent than you yourself sustain.

Which one of the following best illustrates the principle underlying the argument?

A Laws are made to protect people from risks of which they are not fully aware.

B Medical treatment should be limited to those who do not pursue lifestyles which cause medical conditions.

C Spectator events where people take pleasure in others' misfortune should be banned.

D We should not make bonfire parties illegal in the way that arson is.

E Different attitudes to risk in life can be expressed in sport.

22 (2013 Q21) In recent years there has been a great deal of media attention focused on the private lives of politicians and world leaders, with particular attention paid to their personal relationships. There are those who suggest that this attention is unwarranted because only their professional abilities are important to their political role. This attitude fails to consider that the public have little insight into the day-to-day lives of world leaders and, indeed, few points of reference. Personal lives offer common ground. In democratic states leaders are elected based on how the public perceive them, and private lives can offer an insight into an individual's values. The personal aspects of a politician's life should continue to be reported if the electorate find it important.

Which one of the following, if true, most strengthens the above argument?

A All those in the public eye are subjected to media attention.

B Some politicians have high profile affairs.

C Attention on their private lives can cause leaders to lose their focus.

D Many of the public are very interested in the family lives of sports personalities.

E Most politicians claim to be respectable and honest in all aspects of their lives.

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23 (2008 Q41) Electrical goods retailers often offer 'extended warranties' which guarantee free repairs if the product breaks down during the term of the warranty. Salespeople are keen to persuade customers to buy these warranties because they gain substantial commission from them. Customers may also be tempted to buy them, since they ensure that the purchaser will not be faced with huge repair bills. However, surveys by consumer protection agencies show that the average cost of repairs per customer is less than the average cost of a warranty. Anybody buying electrical goods would, therefore, be well-advised not to buy an extended warranty, as it represents poor value for money.

Which one of the following, if true, would weaken the above argument?

A Salespeople knowingly mislead their customers into purchasing a poor value scheme.

B The average cost of repairs is low because for the majority of electrical purchases the actual cost is zero.

C No extended warranty scheme would be viable for the retailer if the average cost of repairs exceeded the cost of the warranty.

D In most warranty agreements there are clauses which state that certain kinds of repair are not covered.

E With or without an extended warranty, customers have statutory rights which retailers are obliged to observe.

24 (2014 Q5) Recent news stories have mistakenly implied that animals can understand mathematics better than humans. Participants in a study were asked to state a choice of one of three doors, behind one of which there was a prize. Then the researcher opened one of the other two doors, revealing that there was no prize behind it. Asked if they would like to change their choice, most chose not to change. Switching to the remaining closed door would have increased their chance of winning. Even after playing the game many times, which allowed them to observe that they would win more often if they switched, most did not do so. When pigeons played a similar game, after a few attempts they switched every time. So the pigeons learnt from experience, whereas the people overanalysed and became confused.

Which one of the following is an assumption underlying the above argument?

A Birds are better than human beings at learning from experience.

B Most people did not notice that they won more often if they switched.

C The people were no better than the pigeons at calculating probability.

D Most people thought that the probability of winning remained the same.

E Learning from experience is not a mathematical process.

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25 (2013 Q9) The recent campaign to reduce the number of people who drive while over the legal alcohol limit was very successful. But reducing it further is going to be difficult without addressing one of the main problems: people in rural areas have no choice, in the absence of public transport, but to use their cars. People who live in towns and cities can use buses, trains or readily available taxis if they want to go out for a drink. Furthermore, they don't have to go far to find pubs and clubs. Unless the Government wants the level of drink-driving to increase, it needs to ensure that far more pubs and clubs are built in rural areas.

Which one of the following, if true, would most strengthen the above argument?

A The legal alcohol limit for drivers is likely to be lowered in the near future.

B The public have been made much more aware of the dangers of drink-driving.

C Many pubs in rural areas are closing because of the reduced numbers of customers.

D The population of rural areas is predicted to increase over the next twenty years.

E The police concentrate their drink-driving campaign in towns and cities.

END OF TEST

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